



“There are tried and tested methods for sustainable business growth. Founders have to understand that, ultimately, they are... catering to... customers”

PADMAJA RUPAREL
CO-FOUNDER,
INDIAN ANGEL NETWORK



“When the market was hot, money was chasing deals, but now deals that would have taken two months to close are running into delays of six to eight months”

K. GANESH
SERIAL ENTREPRENEUR AND
INVESTOR

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Today, IAN claims to be supported by more than 500 investors across nine countries. Among IAN’s successes are Zypp, WOW! Momo, Spinny, Manastu Space, Data Sutram and WebEngage. (D2C food chain WOW! Momo raised funding through IAN in 2015, with InfoE-dge’s Bikhchandani as the lead investor.)

Sagar Daryani, WOW! Momo’s Co-founder and CEO says, “IAN has supported us throughout our growth journey. Regarding compliance with the regulatory framework, one IAN is acting for all. Angel networks are very helpful for your business if you can use them. When we entered Delhi-NCR, we got a lot of support from the network regarding location hunting, connections, contacting vendors, etc.”

According to Daryani, IAN also supported him in

raising funds right after the pandemic when restaurant businesses had just started coming back to life after having to shut their doors during the lockdowns.

So why does IAN go for early-stage start-ups? Ruparel says young start-ups have young founders with little experience. “It is obvious for them to make mistakes, and that’s why early-stage investors should also act as mentors to help them navigate. We intend to give our portfolio start-ups all the support.”

IAN’s mentoring includes getting the start-up the right industry connections, as it did with Dhruva Space, which is building application-agnostic satellite platforms. Chaitanya Dora Surapureddy, Dhruva’s CFO and Co-founder, says IAN has “guided us in everything, including making the right industry connections”.

“IAN is a founder-friendly network that looks at long-term association with founders. Because of the pandemic, there was a year’s gap between our first conversation and raising the funds. But they made sure that funds were raised right, and we saved enough to have a runway for the pandemic,” Surapureddy says.

Does Ruparel or IAN favour women-led start-ups? Not exactly, but Ruparel does try to ensure that women entrepreneurs do not have to face gender-biased questions like, ‘Are you married? What are your maternity plans?’

Ruparel says women lead 23% of IAN’s portfolio. She acknowledges that, at least in India, many women founders face gender-biased questions when they pitch for funding. Such gender stereotypes have existed in Indian society for ages. However, IAN focusses on the founder’s potential, not their gender.

“Though it is hard to avoid sexist actions completely, such as turning to male founders while discussing financials, we try to make sure that no stereotypical questions are asked during the pitch,” Ruparel says. “However, women have to network more, which Indian women have been avoiding over the years due to social stereotypes.”

Ruparel says women have come out in support of other women, created dialogues, and set examples. They could adopt business leaders like Nykaa’s Founder, Falguni Nayar, as role models. “Her work is a landmark example of the paradigm shift in the women-led business landscape in India,” she says.

Nishita Agarwal, Co-founder of Papa Pawsome, a D2C start-up selling organic shampoos and spa kits for pets, did not face gender-biased questions at IAN. “While pitching to other investors, we faced gender-biased questions, but our experience has been smooth with IAN. The best part of the conversation with them is having a single point of contact in the whole organisation,” she says.

Agarwal says IAN’s resourceful investor base gives an edge to the early-stage start-ups it mentors.